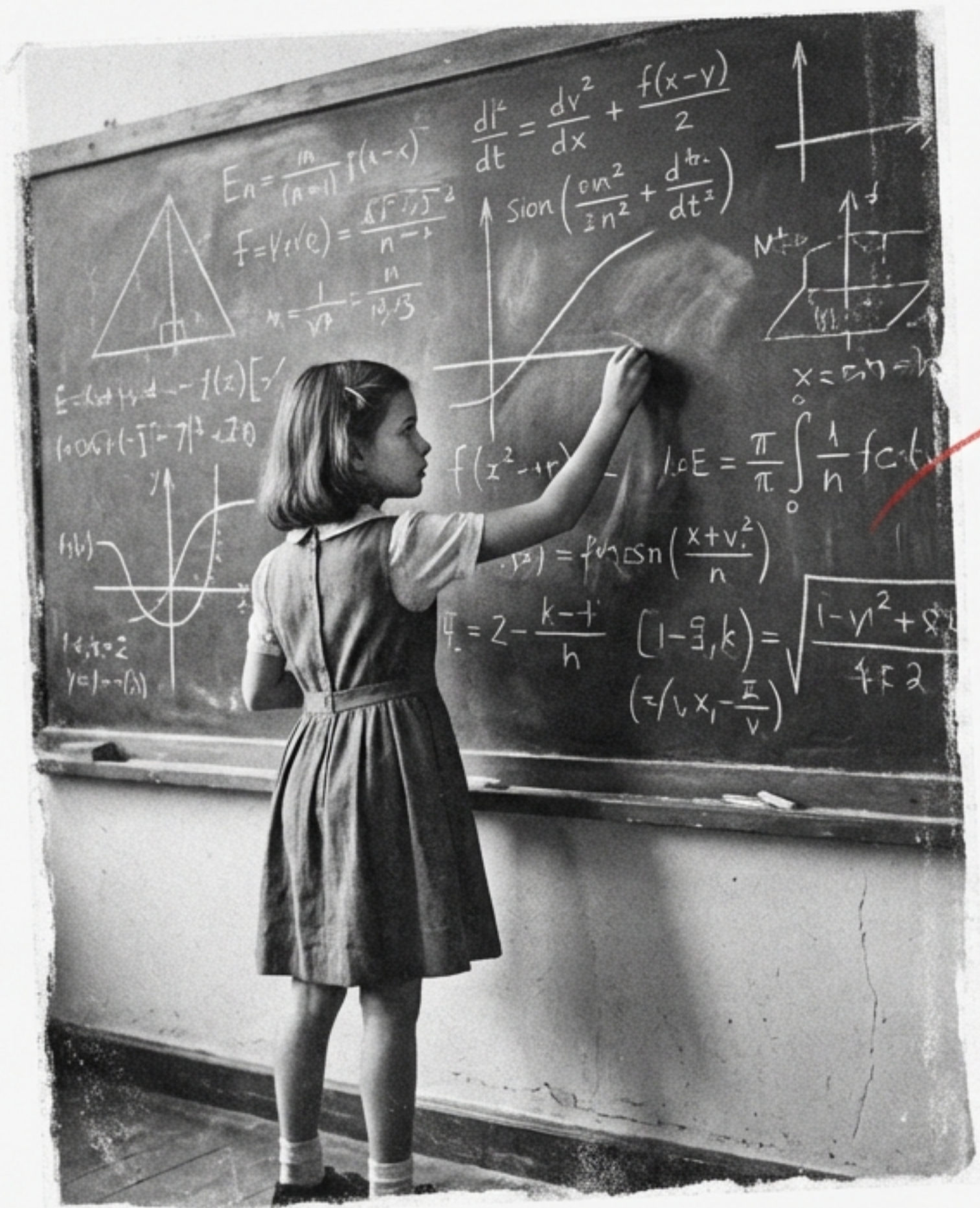


GRIT: THE POWER OF PASSION AND PERSEVERANCE

A forensic analysis of why talent is not a guarantee of success.

Based on the research of Angela Duckworth





THE GENIUS MYTH

“You know, you’re no genius!”

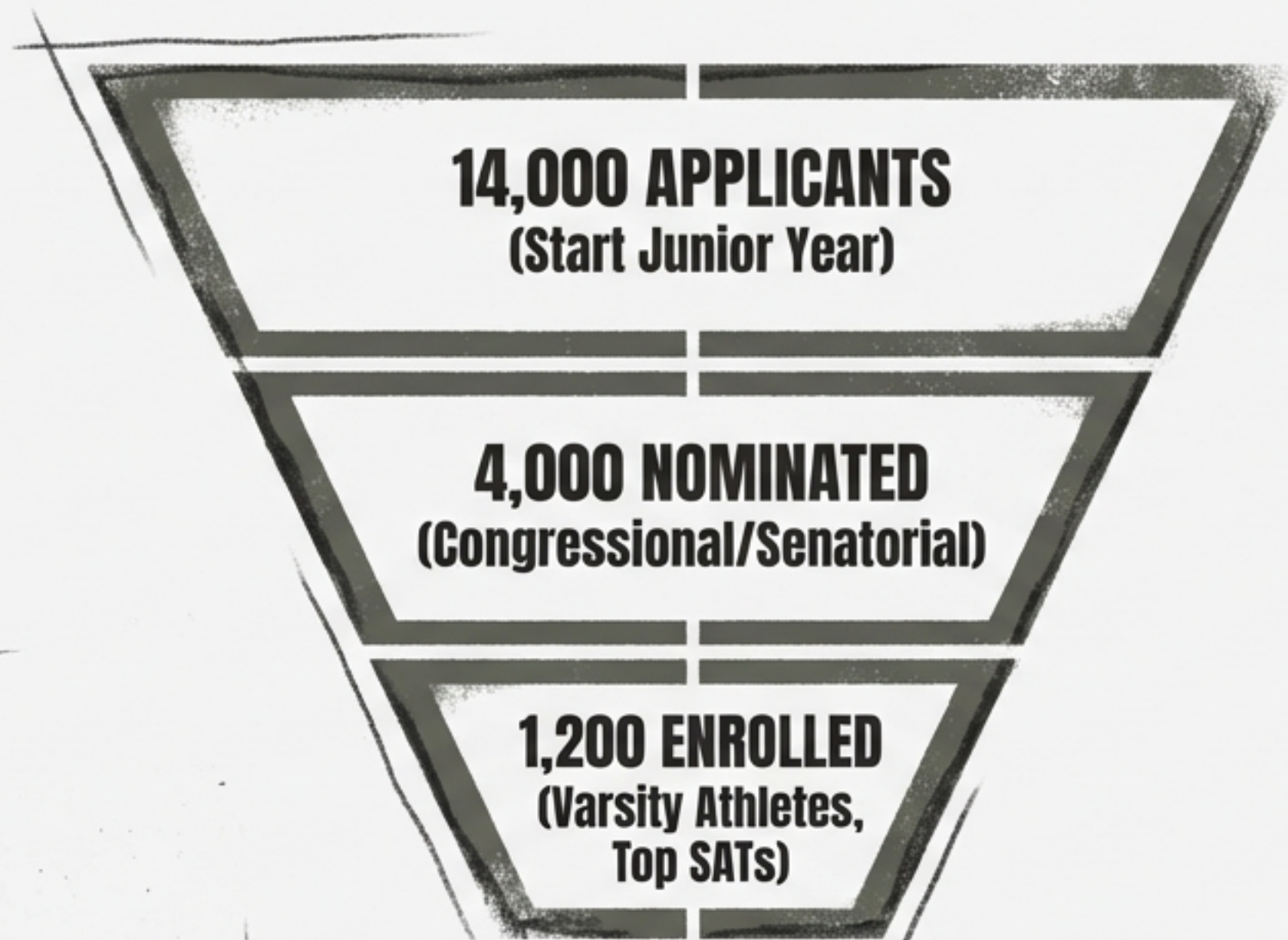
Growing up, Angela Duckworth heard this constantly from her father. He was obsessed with innate intelligence and believed his children didn’t measure up to Einstein.

THE IRONY

Years later, Duckworth was awarded the MacArthur Fellowship—the so-called “Genius Grant”—specifically for proving that effort counts more than ability.

KEY INSIGHT

Her father had the right answer (“No, she’s not a genius”) to the wrong question (“Is she a genius?”). The right question was: “Is she **gritty?**” ← ?



1 in 5 DROP OUT before graduation. Significant attrition during “Beast Barracks” (First Summer).

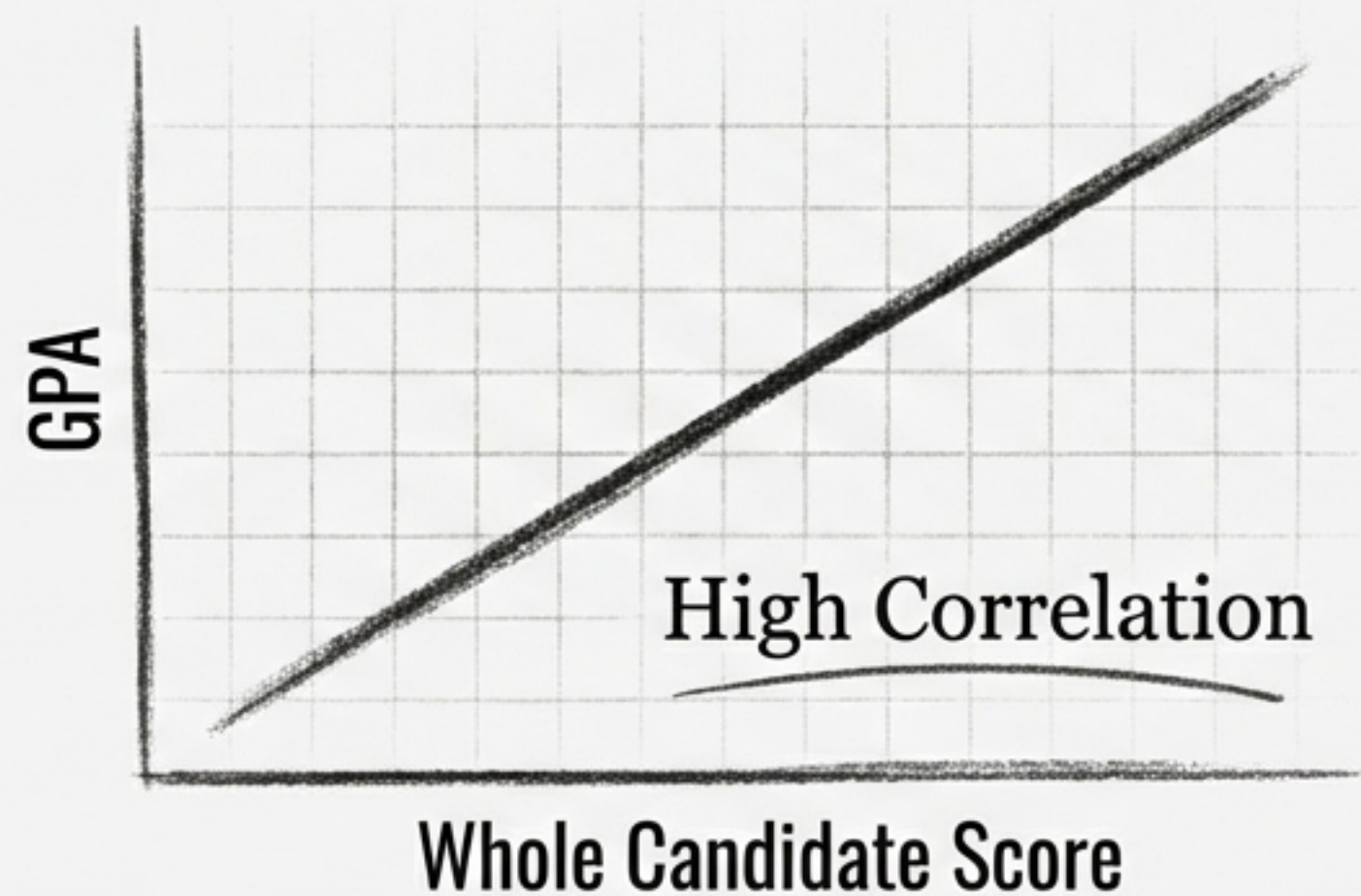
THE WEST POINT PUZZLE

The Context: “Beast Barracks” is a grueling 7-week training program designed to break new cadets physically and mentally.

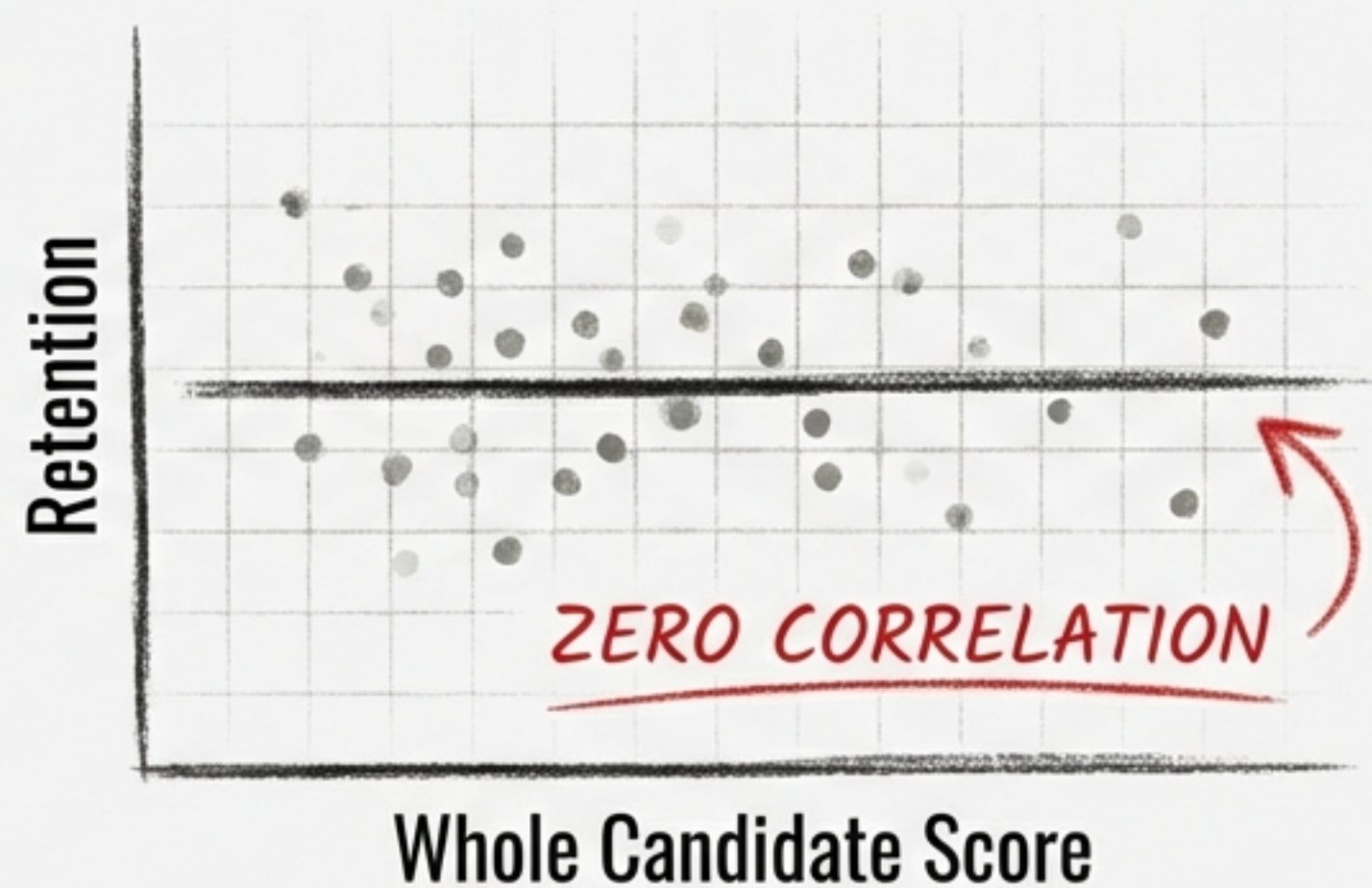
The Mystery: These are the elite of the elite. They spent two years trying to get in. Why do they quit in the first two months?

THE FAILURE OF THE “WHOLE CANDIDATE SCORE”

Predicting Academic Grades



Predicting Retention (Beast Barracks)



The Whole Candidate Score (SATs, Rank, Physical Fitness, Leadership) is the single most important factor in admission. It accurately predicts grades. It failed completely to predict who would quit. The “talented” were just as likely to drop out as the struggle-prone.

THE MISSING VARIABLE

The Grit Scale (Passion + Perseverance)

Duckworth administered the Grit Scale to 1,218 cadets. It was the only reliable predictor of survival. This predictive power extends beyond the military:



Sales:

Predicted retention in vacation time-share companies (where attrition is 55%).



Education:

Predicted graduation rates in Chicago Public Schools.



Special Forces:

Predicted survival in the Green Beret "Selection Course."



Spelling Bee:

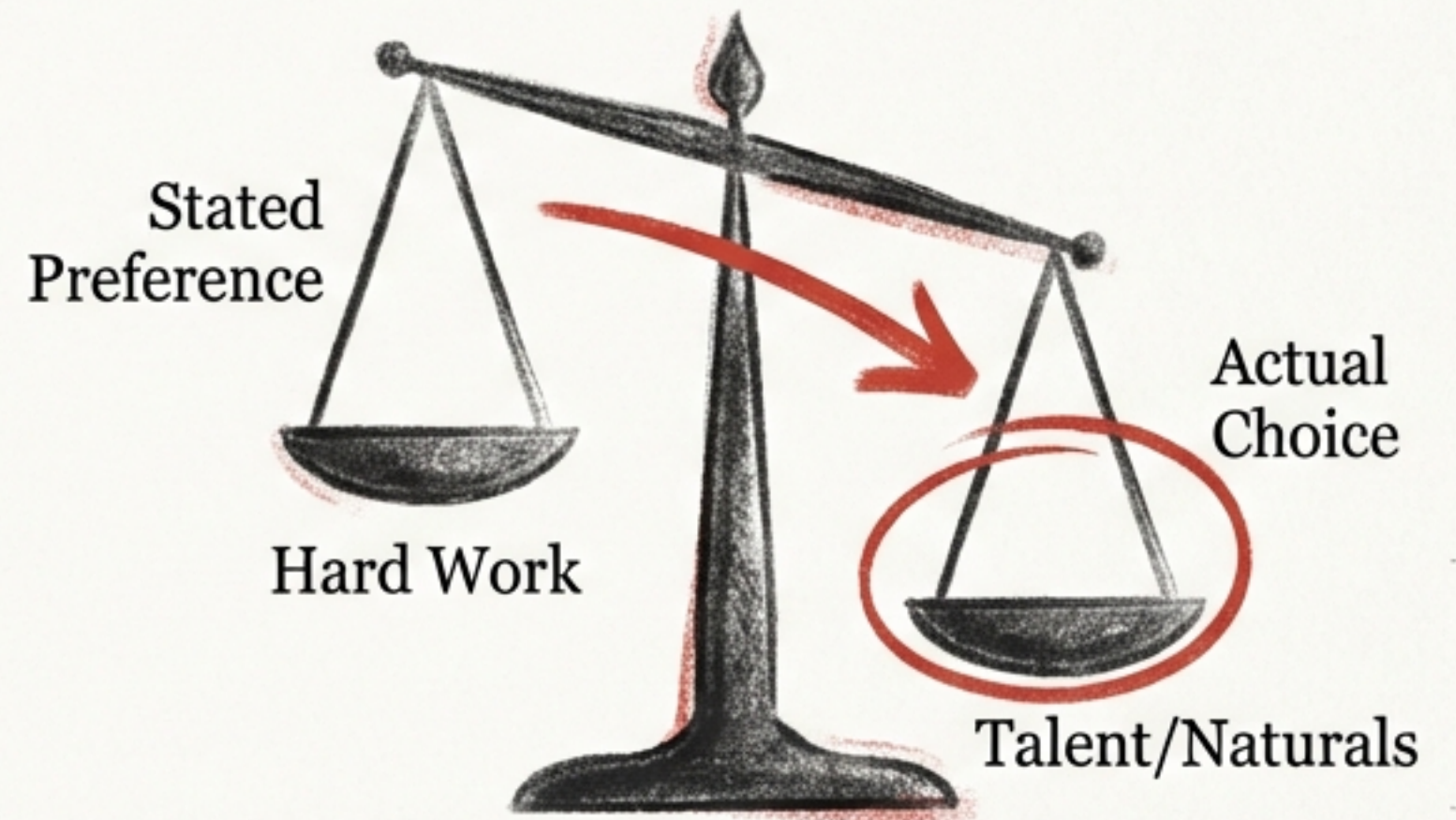
Predicted which finalists went the furthest (outperforming Verbal IQ).

THE NATURALNESS BIAS

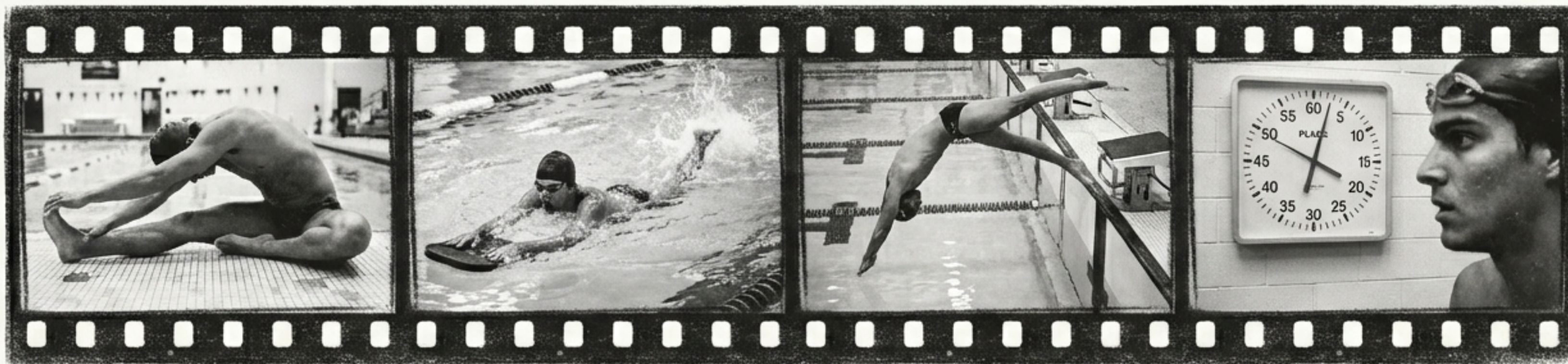
“Our vanity, our self-love, promotes the cult of the genius. For if we think of genius as something magical, we are not obliged to compare ourselves and find ourselves lacking.” — Friedrich Nietzsche”

The Paradox: Americans claim to value “hard workers” over “intelligence” by a 5:1 ratio.

The Reality: In studies of musicians and entrepreneurs, when presented with identical achievements, people consistently judged the “Natural” as more hireable and successful than the “Striver.”



THE MUNDANITY OF EXCELLENCE



The “Fish” Myth:

When Mark Spitz won 7 gold medals, observers said, “He’s a fish.” They ignored the 12 years of training that created the form.

“ Superlative performance is really a confluence of dozens of small skills or activities... carefully drilled into habit.” — Dan Chambliss ”

We prefer the mystery of the “fish” to the boredom of the drill.

Forensic Intellectual

YOU DON'T HAVE A THEORY.

The Challenge: In a meeting with Marty Seligman (founder of Positive Psychology), Duckworth was told she had good data but no theory. She needed to explain *how* talent, effort, skill, and achievement fit together.



THE MECHANICS OF ACHIEVEMENT

talent x *effort* = skill



Effort Counts Twice.

1. Effort builds the skill.
2. Effort makes the skill productive.

skill x *effort* = achievement

Talent is merely the speed at which you improve.
Grit is what turns that potential into reality.

QUANTITY LEADS TO QUALITY.

The Pottery Parable: A pottery class was divided into two groups: "Quantity" (graded on weight of pots produced) and "Quality" (graded on producing one perfect pot).

The Outcome: The highest quality pots were produced by the "Quantity" group.

The Mechanism:

- **Talent x Effort = Skill:** Making 50 pots built the neural pathways.
- **Skill x Effort = Achievement:** They used that new skill to produce better art.
- The "Quality" group sat theorizing about perfection and produced mediocre work.



THE PROCESS



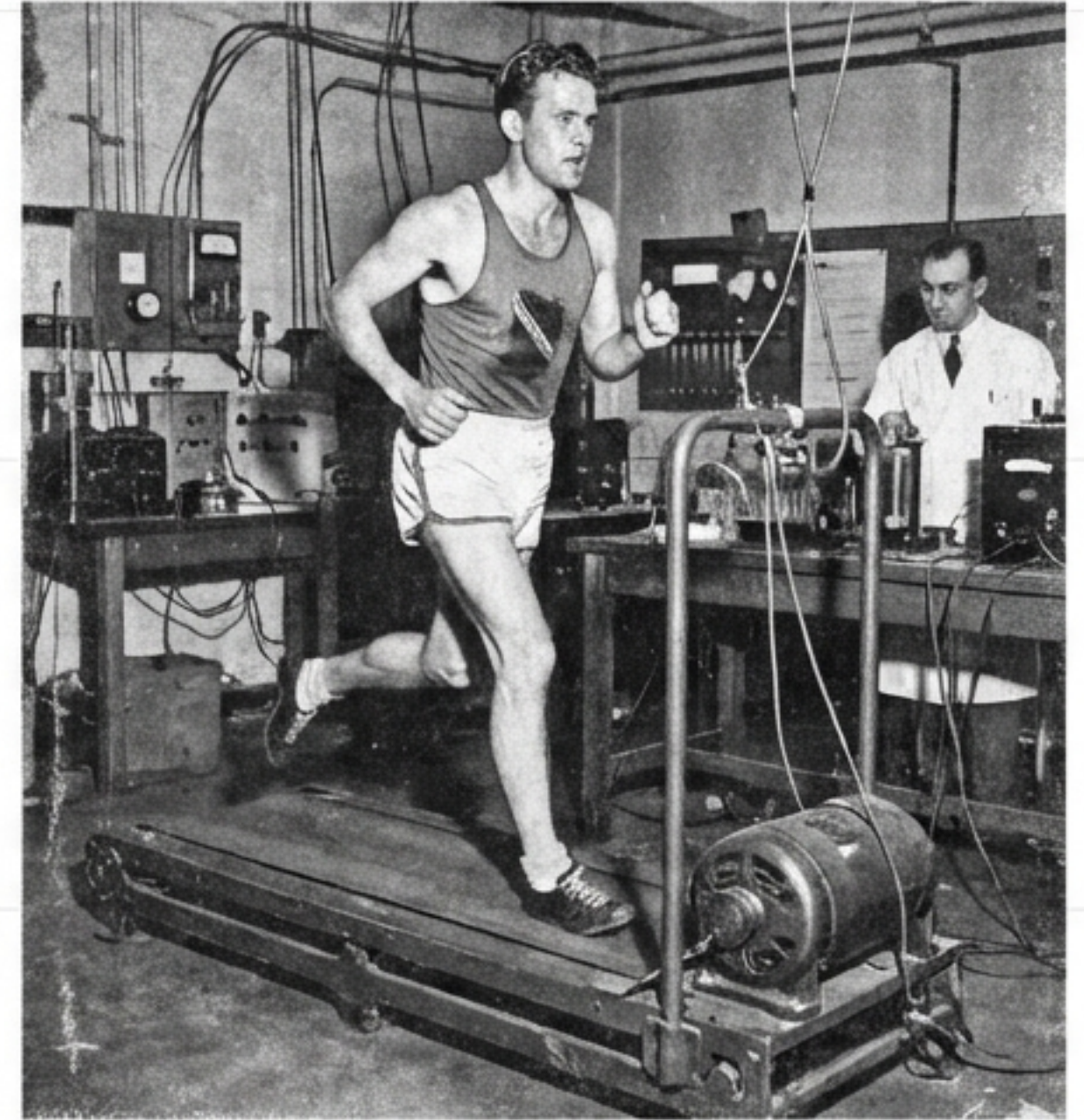
THE RESULT

THE TREADMILL

“The only thing that is distinctly different about me is: I’m not afraid to die on a treadmill. I will not be outworked, period.” — Will Smith

The Science: Harvard Treadmill Study (1940)

- 130 sophomores ran on a steep treadmill until exhaustion.
- The test measured “strength of will,” not just fitness.
- **Finding:** Treadmill time at age 20 predicted psychological adjustment at age 60.



HOW GRITTY ARE YOU?

FACTOR 1: PASSION

(Consistency of interest)

- ☒ New ideas do not distract me.
- ☒ My interests do not change from year to year.
- ☒ I have been obsessed with a certain idea for a long time.

FACTOR 2: PERSEVERANCE

(Resilience)

- ☒ Setbacks don't discourage me.
- ☒ I am a hard worker.
- ☒ I finish whatever I begin.

Most people score higher on Perseverance. It is easier to work hard than to maintain a singular focus for decades.

PASSION IS A COMPASS, NOT FIREWORKS



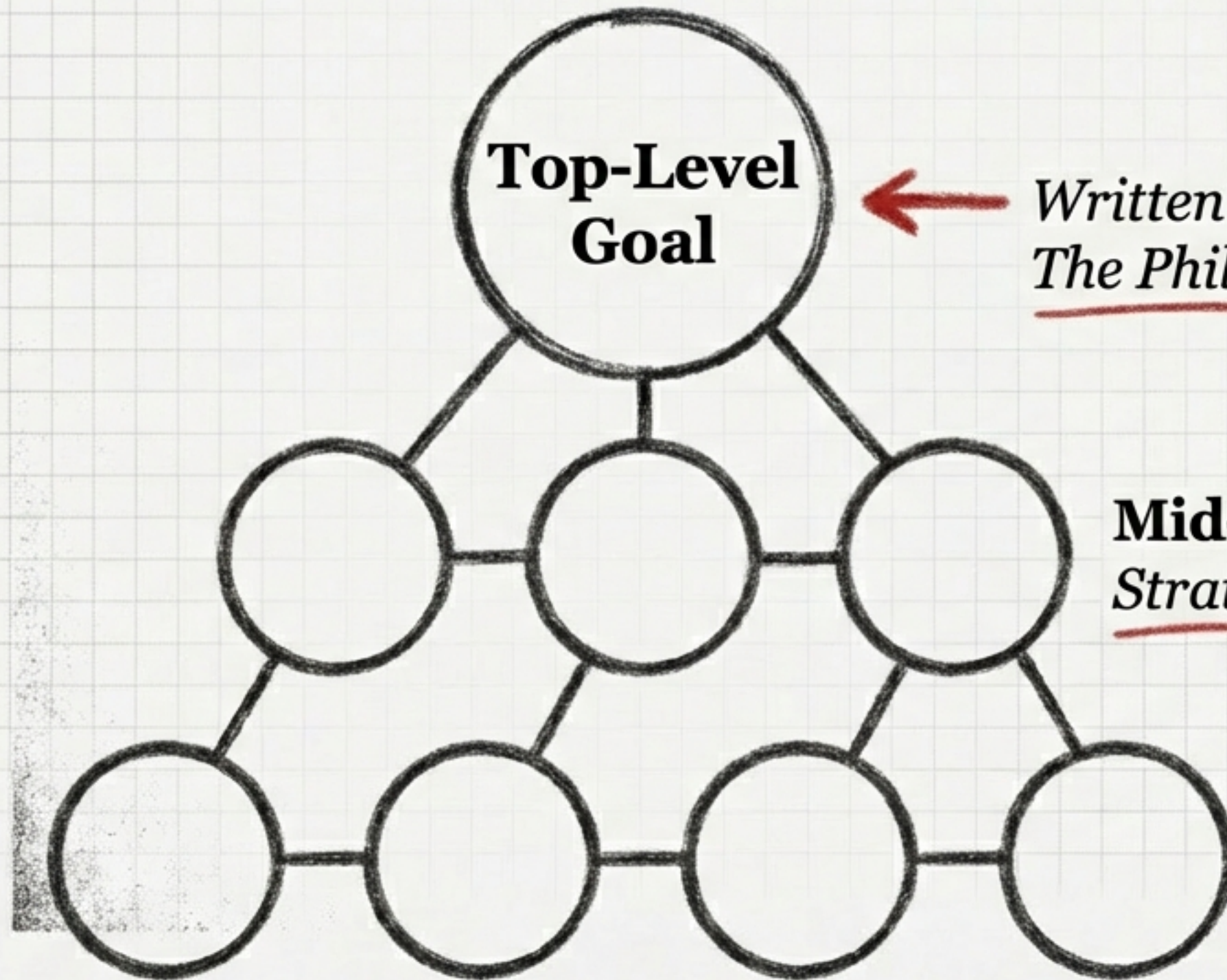
The Compass vs. The Fireworks

We often confuse passion with intensity (infatuation). True passion is consistency—waking up thinking about the same questions as yesterday.

Case Study: Jeff Gettleman (NYT Bureau Chief)

- **Goal:** “Live and work in East Africa.”
- **Strategy:** Journalism.
- **The Path:** Oxford -> Wisconsin -> Florida -> Atlanta -> Overseas -> East Africa.
- Journalism was the means to the end. It took ten years of winding paths to arrive.

THE GOAL HIERARCHY



Top-Level Goal

← *Written in Ink.
The Philosophy.*

Mid-Level Goals
Strategy.

Low-Level Goals
Written in Pencil. To-Do List.

Tom Seaver:

Top: Pitch the best I can day after day.

Mid: Stay healthy / Perfect mechanics.

Low: Eat cottage cheese / Pitch with left hand to save right.

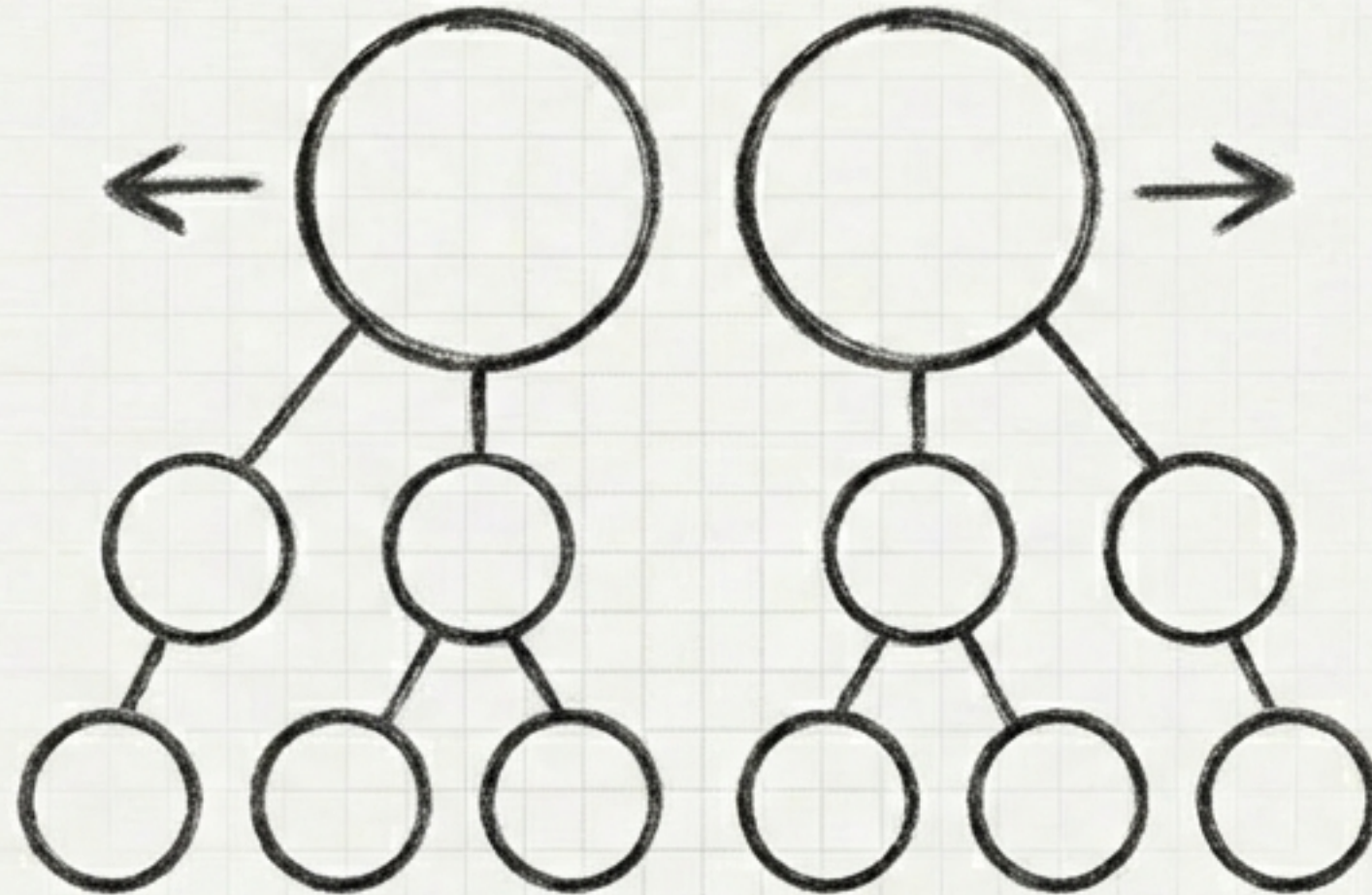
DIAGNOSING A LACK OF GRIT

Positive Fantasizing



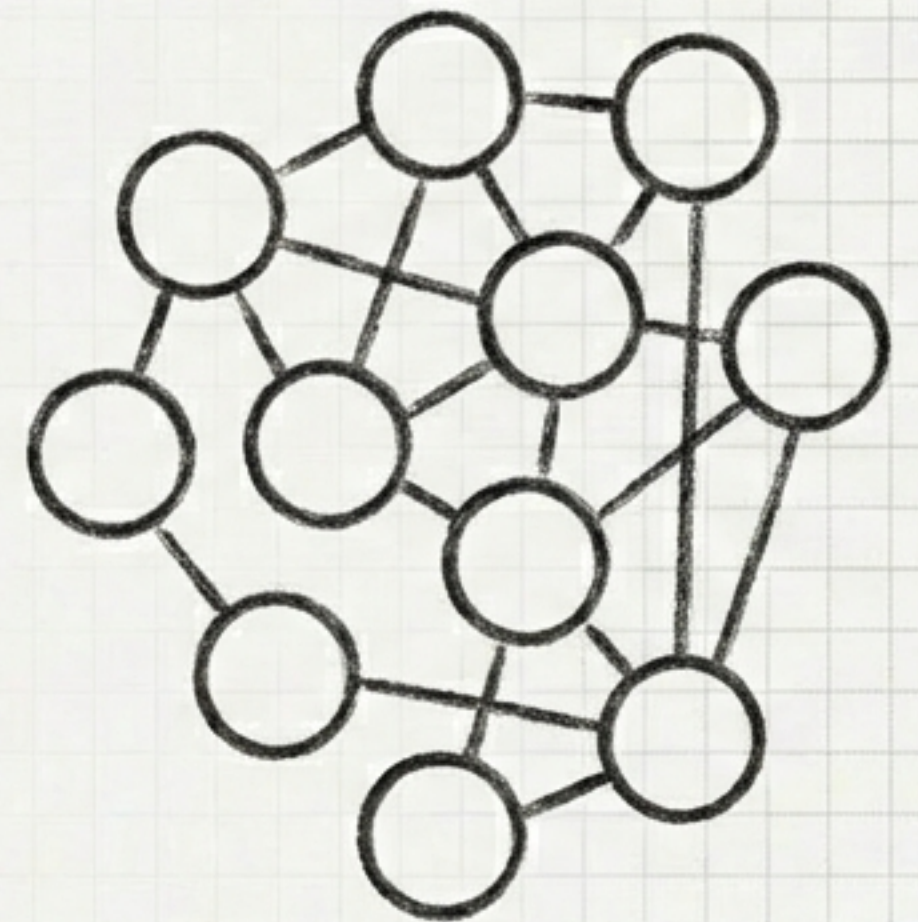
A dream without a plan.

Goal Conflict



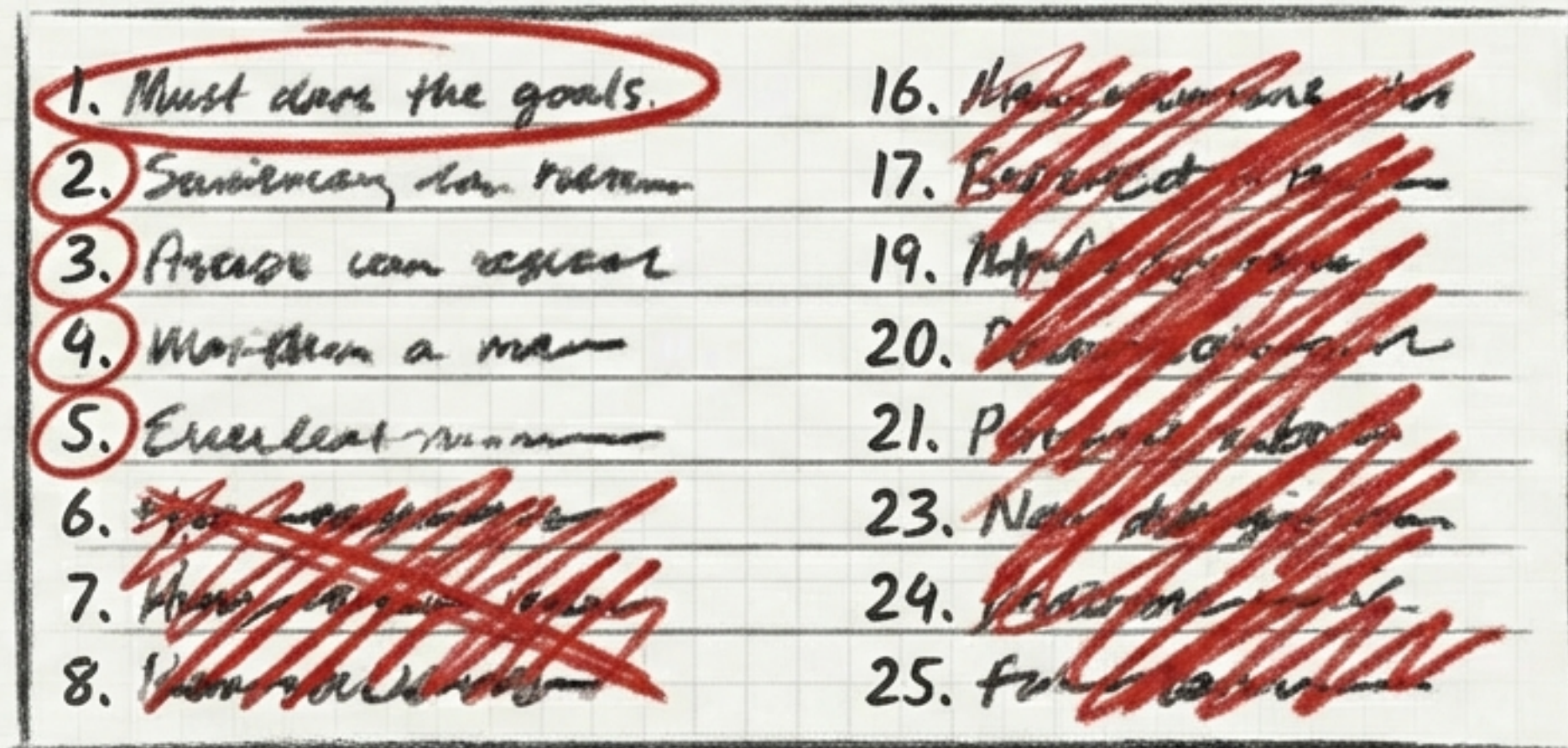
Goal Conflict

Fragmented Goals



A bunch of motion,
no direction.

THE WARREN BUFFETT METHOD (The 25/5 Rule)



Step 1: Write down 25 career goals. **Step 2:** Circle the top 5.

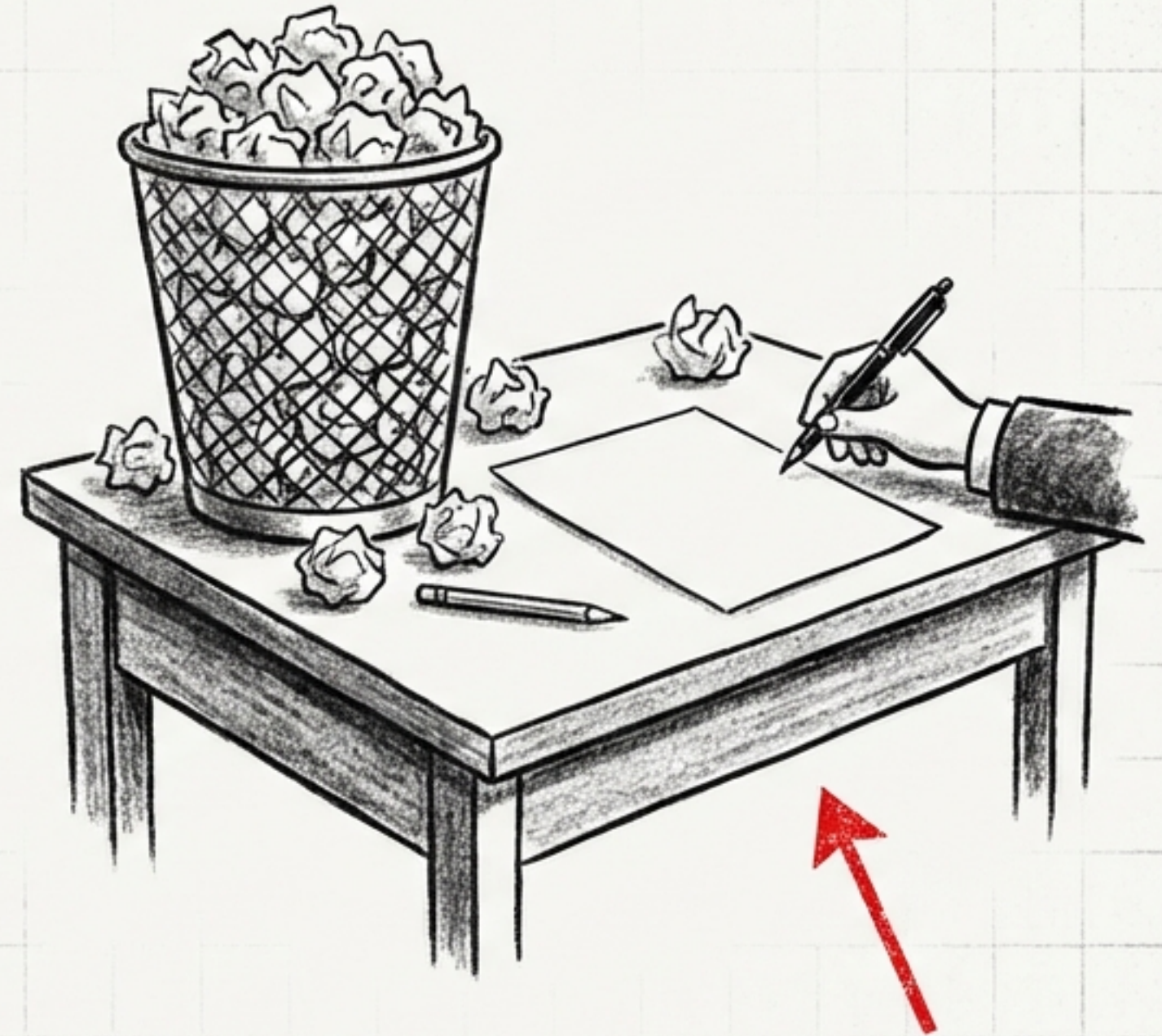
Step 3: The remaining 20 are not your “backup plan.” They are your **Avoid-At-All-Costs** list.

→ **KEY INSIGHT:** Success requires pruning the “good” goals to feed the “ultimate” ones.

WRITTEN IN PENCIL VS. WRITTEN IN INK

Case Study: Bob Mankoff (New Yorker Cartoon Editor)

- **The Data:** Rejection rate **>96%**. (500 submissions/week -> **17 published**).
- **The Gritty Response:** Mankoff submitted **2,000 cartoons** before getting a contract.



Grit is not stubbornness. You must be willing to erase low-level goals (**pencil**) to preserve the top-level goal (**ink**). "Improvise, adapt, overcome."

THE ARCHITECTURE OF GRIT

$Talent \times \text{Effort} = Skill$

$Skill \times \text{Effort} = Achievement$



TEXT SUMMARY

Talent: How fast you improve.

Grit: The passion to begin and the perseverance to continue.

Excellence: Not divine intervention, but the result of holding a top-level goal for a very long time and letting effort count twice.

THE LONG RUN



**“IN THE LONG RUN, GRIT MAY
MATTER MORE THAN TALENT.”**

Angela Duckworth